

The Urban Digest

VOL. 1, NO. 089

2026-03-30

FRONT PAGE

Leave no trace rafting through the Grand Canyon this year

Teresa Bergen · Inhabitat

It's a hot and beautiful summer day at the bottom of the Grand Canyon as I stand in line for a sandwich. Our rafting guides have set up an amazing spread of fixings. There's even vegan cheese for me. All that's missing are plates and napkins. After washing our hands with river water and soap in a foot-pumped bucket sink, we put our bread on one hand and try to layer on all the sandwich ingredients with the other. Scooping out avocado is especially difficult one-handed. It's clumsy, but admirable when you realize we are generating no paper or plastic trash. Then we sit at the river's edge so that the rainbow trout can eat any of our food.

FEATURES

DUM-E and U

Jessie Frazelle

DUM-E (“dummy”) and U (“you”) are the names of the robot arms in the Iron Man movies. After watching this movie for the n-teenth time, I have a strong urge to also have robotic arms in a workshop like Tony Stark. You can see the value of the robots clearly throughout the movie. The robots allow Tony to produce suits more quickly, help test the suits, and provide periodic comedic relief. At one point, DUM-E even saves Tony’s life. As a bit of a thought experiment, I considered what it would take to get the same functionality in reality. What this ends up leading to is a configuration management system for manufacturing, much like a build system. This post is going to outline that a bit!

The most popular open-source framework for building robots is ROS (Robotics Operating System) . You can add different components like cameras or sensors and program all the functionality you need for your specific use case. The underlying infrastructure works by passing messages, through a pub/subsystem. Elementary Robotics created their own OS called atom . It’s pretty cool, it uses Redis for the messaging layer and docker for packaging and defining the individual components. Need a camera on your robot? Include the camera container in your atom OS config file. You can then pipe the messages from the camera into machine learning in another container. It’s important to know the basics of these frameworks to continue into how we would build DUM-E and U.

Let’s dive in. The end goal here is to be as productive as Tony Stark at building things.

Fire extinguisher robot

One of my favorite scenes with DUM-E is when Tony is testing the suits and it’s DUM-E’s job to blast him with a fire extinguisher when he is on fire. For comic relief in the movie, DUM-E messes this up a bunch and blasts Tony when he’s not on fire.

Let’s break this down, starting with a robot that will shoot a fire extinguisher on any fire. First, what you would need is the robotic arm base, maybe you build your own, maybe it’s ABB, Kuka, FANUC, or any other robot arm maker. Let’s assume you have some sort of robotic arm with an SDK/API you can program. You also need a fire extinguisher. Since we are hackers we will just duct tape this to the robot arm and have a trigger on the switch to fire it programmatically. Next, we need a camera. Let’s also duct tape this and all the wires to the robot. We need to know if something in our proximity is on fire and where it is. We will need some code to determine if something is on fire. You could likely train a machine learning model to do this. So when the ML model identifies something as on fire, we need to calculate where it is in relation to the distance from the camera identifying it to the fire extinguisher we duct-taped to the robot. This is all doable and pretty much depends on how well we trained our model.

In the movie, DUM-E is quite bad at identifying fire. It is just a movie but we should consider it might be hard for the model to differentiate fire from the color of the suit when it’s not on fire. If you recall, Iron Man’s suit is crimson and gold which could be misidentified as fire if it’s moving in the same pattern a fire might move. Tony does fly and move around at very fast speeds. This really comes down to how well Tony trains the model. As long as DUM-E continually learns, which he should, by the time Iron Man has been blasted by mistake a few times, the model should know the difference between the two (on fire and suit that looks like fire moving in a weird way). We also get to witness this learning in the movie.

DUM-E, despite his namesake, is very intelligent. A major scene in the movie is when he saves Tony’s life by passing him the reactor to power the magnet in his chest. The reactor is just out of Tony’s reach as he is dying and DUM-E realizes this and passes it to him. This could be programmed in a few different ways.

One way would be the equivalent of hard coding this behavior. Maybe Tony trained DUM-E to pass him the reactor. That’s a bit lame and wouldn’t be very useful outside this context. Let’s assume DUM-E was programmed a different way.

What would be more useful overall is if DUM-E had some programming that when Tony is reaching for an object just outside his reach, DUM-E should know to pass it to him. Again this relies on a camera and a very precise machine learning model. Instead of the fire extinguisher though, we would need a claw to pick up the object and pass it. The machine learning model for this behavior would have to:

Identify a human

Identify the difference between a human in a resting state and a human reaching for something, arms extended

Identify the object the human is reaching for, scan for objects a certain distance from the end of the hand

We’d also want some code to know when the object is out of reach and the robot should help or if the human is fine on their own, don’t want the robot arm getting in my way when I actually want to grab something. So maybe watch the rate of the reach and calculate if it’s possible for the arm to extend to any objects around where it is headed.

This should all be possible. For bonus points let’s make it even more useful. Tony uses his robots to help him build things in his workshop and at times he asks them to pass him tools. Let’s add a microphone component to the robot and a model to identify when I am asking for an object. Now the robot needs to correctly identify objects based on a name, and let’s hope it parses what I said correctly in the first place. We could also help the robot identify objects, by using the camera to identify if I pointed to a specific object when I asked for it. This would be super helpful and like having another set of arms around.

L-Tyrosine Supplements: Benefits for Your Brain and Body

Greatist

Explore L-tyrosine benefits: A nonessential amino acid that may boost mood, enhance cognitive performance, and manage stress. Discover how supplements and foods rich in L-tyrosine can support your health.

L-tyrosine is an amino acid (AKA protein building block) that supports your body, from your muscles to your noggin.

It's a non-essential amino acid, which means your body can make it on its own, so you don't have to get it from food

That being said, consuming foods high in L-tyrosine or taking supplements could have extra cognitive and physical benefits – here's what to know.

What is L-tyrosine?

L-tyrosine is an amino acid that the body produces naturally. Though your bod can prob create enough of the stuff on its own, some research suggests that supplementing with it can boost your mood and help regulate your stress response.

L-tyrosine helps make many vital chemical messengers , such as:

dopamine, the “feel good” chemical associated with pleasure, motivation, and reward

adrenaline , your “fight or flight” hormone, which triggers you to act fast under stress

norepinephrine , a hormone that helps with focus and alertness

thyroid hormones , which regulate metabolism and energy

melanin , which gives your skin, hair , and eyes its pigment

Supplementing with L-tyrosine is believed by some to boost levels of dopamine, adrenalin, and norepinephrine in particular.

Foods naturally high in tyrosine include :

cheese

soybeans

beef

lamb

pork

chicken

fish

nuts

eggs

dairy

beans

whole grains

Boost brainpower

L-tyrosine may improve your memory and mental alertness . Since L-tyrosine increases dopamine availability in your body, experts think it may boost your cognitive performance. In addition to reward centers, dopamine is linked to working memory processes and plays a key role in the brain's aging process.

In a 2019 review of several studies, researchers found that a higher intake of L-tyrosine was linked to improved cognition. It also improved executive functions like brain flexibility, convergent thinking, and reasoning.

However, researchers noted that L-tyrosine is most effective when dopamine and norepinephrine levels are reduced (which basically means when you feel stressed AF).

Improve your mood

Some L-tyrosine supplement companies claim that their products are both mood boosters and antidepressants, but the results are mixed.

L-tyrosine increases dopamine, the feel-good hormone that's linked to reward processing and also addiction. In general, it's been shown to be a vital regulator of mood, behavior, and brainpower – so it makes sense that getting enough of it could benefit your mood, too.

However, the research on supplementation of tyrosine for depression is super dated , so it's challenging to draw any definitive conclusions RN. (Plus, depression is also a super complex condition that involves more than just dopamine depletion.)

And though there are some people dubbing L-tyrosine “natural Adderall” for its purported beneficial effect on ADHD, so far, there's no research to support these claims yet, either. (Though it *is* true that there seems to be a link between ADHD and altered dopamine levels.)

Amino acid link

Phenylketonuria is a rare genetic disorder in which the body can't properly process another essential amino acid, phenylalanine.

Since those with the disorder may also be deficient in L-tyrosine, some experts think that supplementing with it could help relieve some symptoms like seizures or skin rashes.

GRT test noom med epm

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Combines behavioral changes with prescription GLP-1 medications

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Weight Loss Designed For You, Trusted By Us

Noom Med is an accessible and affordable weight loss program that pairs psychology with medication, ensuring healthy transformation and lasting results .

With Noom Med and GLP-1 medication, users experience 48% more weight loss in 6 months than those using medications alone.*

Noom understands that weight loss is most effective when tailored to your individual needs. Complete a quick online quiz, and Noom will recommend a custom plan to achieve your health goals.

97% of doctors recommend combining GLP-1s with lifestyle changes. ^ That's why the Noom app provides a GLP-1 companion to support reliable and long-lasting healthy habits .

Users benefit from 100% online access to Noom's expert clinical team and coaches . No in-person appointments means fast and convenient weight management.

You can access Noom's proven and trusted weight loss program via the companion app, designed to enhance the benefits of GLP-1 medications with specialized workouts, recipes, and tracking features .

Andrea's Success With Noom Med

Andrea G, 36, lost 65 lbs in 93 weeks.

"Noom truly changed my life. It taught me how to make small, sustainable changes that add up to lasting success. I've tried everything—other apps, macro counting, paid trainers, fad diets—but nothing has given me the long-term results and balance that Noom has." †

Effective Weight Loss in Five Simple Steps

Noom ensures your weight loss journey starts right, by guiding you throughout the process. Noom Med follows these simple steps:

Fill out a quick clinical survey about your health history and goals, and verify your identity.

A licensed clinician will evaluate your results to determine if a prescription is best for you. This can all be conveniently completed in the app.

Noom's insurance concierge helps determine the costs, saving you the hassle of navigating insurance on your own. The Noom Med program is also FSA & HSA eligible .

Receive your prescribed medication within 7 days .

Receive ongoing care from trained coaches alongside unlimited medication refills and contact with your clinician , where appropriate.

Cam's Success With Noom Med

Cam K, 29, lost 35 lbs in 35 weeks.

"My experience working with Noom has been nothing short of fantastic. Since starting Noom, I've noticed a significant reduction in food noise and cravings and, thanks to the lessons and coaching support, I feel confident that I have built up health habits that will help me maintain my weight loss for years to come." †

Choose Noom Med for Safe and Long Lasting Results

If you qualify for Noom Med, you can choose between two different paths: Noom GLP-1 RX Program or Microdose GLP-1rx Program RX , and Branded medications . Pricing for Noom Med varies based on your chosen plan.

Branded GLP-1 medications available through Noom Med includes:

The microdosing GLP-1 program provides users with a lower dose of GLP-1s, decreasing potential side effects.

The microdosing program includes access to the companion app alongside regular, at-home biomarker testing.

*Based on a retrospective study of self-reported data of pounds lost for active versus passive users who were offered the Noom program when being prescribed an early stage GLP-1.

When .animation animates more (or less) than it's supposed to

Ole Begemann

On the positioning of the .animation modifier in the view tree, or: “Rendering” vs. “non-rendering” view modifiers

The documentation for SwiftUI's animation modifier says:

Applies the given animation to this view when the specified value changes.

This sounds unambiguous to me: it sets the animation for “this view”, i.e. the part of the view tree that `.animation` is being applied to. This should give us complete control over which modifiers we want to animate, right? Unfortunately, it’s not that simple: it’s easy to run into situations where a view change inside an animated subtree doesn’t get animated, or vice versa.

Unsurprising examples

Let me give you some examples, starting with those that do work as documented. I tested all examples on iOS 16.1 and macOS 13.0.

1. Sibling views can have different animations

Independent subtrees of the view tree can be animated independently. In this example we have three sibling views, two of which are animated with different durations, and one that isn't animated at all:

```
struct Example1 : View { var flag : Bool
```

```
var body : some View { HStack ( spacing : 40 ) { Rectangle ( .  
frame ( width : 80 , height : 80 ) . foregroundColor ( . green ) .  
scaleEffect ( flag ? 1 : 1.5 ) . animation ( . easeOut ( duration :  
0.5 ) , value : flag )
```

```
Rectangle () . frame ( width : 80 , height : 80 ) . foreground-
Color ( flag ? . yellow : . red ) . rotationEffect ( flag ? . zero : .
degrees ( 45 ) ) . animation ( . easeOut ( duration : 2.0 ) , value :
flag )
```

```
Rectangle () . frame ( width : 80 , height : 80 ) . foreground-  
Color ( flag ? . pink : . mint ) } } }
```

The two animation modifiers each apply to their own subtree. They don't interfere with each other and have no effect on the rest of the view hierarchy:

Download video

2. Nested animation modifiers

When two animation modifiers are nested in a single view tree such that one is an indirect parent of the other, the inner modifier can override the outer animation for its sub-views. The outer animation applies to view modifiers that are placed between the two animation modifiers.

In this example we have one rectangle view with animated scale and rotation effects. The outer animation applies to the entire subtree, including both effects. The inner animation modifier overrides the outer animation only for what's nested below it in the view tree, i.e. the scale effect:

```
struct Example2 : View { var flag : Bool
```

```
var body : some View { Rectangle () . frame ( width : 80 ,
height : 80 ) . foregroundColor ( . green ) . scaleEffect ( flag ?
1 : 1.5 ) . animation ( . default , value : flag ) /\ inner .
rotationEffect ( flag ? . zero : . degrees ( 45 ) ) . animation ( .
default . speed ( 0.3 ) , value : flag ) /\ outer } }
```

As a result, the scale and rotation changes animate at different speeds:

Download video

Note that we can also pass `.animation(nil, value: flag)` to selectively disable animations for a subtree, overriding a non-`nil` animation further up the view tree.

3. animation only animates its children (with exceptions)

As a general rule, the animation modifier only applies to its subviews. In other words, views and modifiers that are direct or indirect parents of an animation modifier should not be animated. As we'll see below, it doesn't always work like that, but here's an example where it does. This is a slight variation of the previous code snippet where I removed the outer animation modifier (and changed the color for good measure):

```
struct Example3 : View { var flag : Bool
```

```
var body : some View { Rectangle () . frame ( width : 80 ,
height : 80 ) . foregroundColor ( . orange ) . scaleEffect ( flag ?
1 : 1.5 ) . animation ( . default , value : flag ) / \ Don't animate
the rotation . rotationEffect ( flag ? . zero : . degrees ( 45 ) ) }
```

Recall that the order in which view modifiers are written in code is inverted with respect to the actual view tree hierarchy. Each view modifier is a new view that wraps the view it's being applied to. So in our example, the scale effect is the child of the animation modifier, whereas the rotation effect is its parent. Accordingly, only the scale change gets animated:

Download video

the border should grow and shrink smoothly: `struct Example5 : View { var flag : Bool var body : some View { Rectangle ()}.`

Ole Begemann

Surprising examples

Think modern people are becoming more comfortable with digital business information technology. Is this changing what all levels

Digging into RISC-V and how I learn new things

Jessie Frazelle

I recently have started researching and playing around with RISC-V for fun. I thought it might be nice to combine some of what I've learned into a blog post. However, I don't just want to highlight what I learned. I want to use this as an example of how to go about learning something new.

Recently, Erik St. Martin , Shubheksha Jalan , and I were discussing how we learn new things and we all thought it might be beneficial to have a way to document this process for others. What better way to document this than by example with my recent research into RISC-V?

I've said it before and I will say it again, I think anyone is capable of doing or learning anything, they just need the right motivation and to believe in themselves. I also made a point of including the book *Super Brain* on my list of recommended books , because it confirms with science that if you set your sights high you can accomplish great things, but if you set your expectations low it becomes a self-fulfilling prophecy. To put it more bluntly, believe in yourself!

I became fascinated by what is happening in the RISC-V space just by seeing it pop up every now and then in my Twitter feed. Since I am currently unemployed I have a lot of time and autonomy to dig into whatever I wish.

RISC-V is a new instruction set architecture. To understand RISC-V, we must first dig into what an instruction set architecture is. This is my learning technique. I bounce from one thing to another, recursively digging deeper as I learn more.

What is an instruction set architecture (ISA)?

An instruction set architecture is the interface between the hardware and the software.

Models of processors can implement the same instruction set but have different internal designs for implementing the interface. This leads to various processors having the same instruction set but differing in performance, physical size, and monetary cost. For example, Intel and AMD have processors that both implement the same x86 instruction set but have very different internal designs.

In order to dig deeper, we should look into what some of the various types of instruction set architectures are.

What are the types of instruction set architectures?

Most commonly these are described and classified by their complexity.

Reduced Instruction Set Computer (RISC)

This only implements frequently used instructions, less common operations are implemented as subroutines. By using subroutines, there is a trade-off of performance, however it's only applied to the least common operations.

RISC uses a load/store architecture; meaning it divides instructions into ones that access memory and ones that perform arithmetic logic unit (ALU) operations.

RISC, the name, came out of Berkeley in the 1980s (from a project led by David Patterson) around the same time MIPS (a project led by John L. Hennessy) was going on at Stanford. RISC became commercialized as SPARC by Sun Microsystems and MIPS became commercialized by MIPS Computer Systems. Both are RISC architectures. You might also be familiar with more modern implementations like ARM or PowerPC which are commercialized as well. There are many RISC implementations other than just these, I implore you all to dig further if you so choose.

RISC architectures can also be traced back to before the name existed as well. Examples include Alan Turing's Automatic Computing Engine (ACE) from 1946 and the CDC 6600 designed by Seymour Cray in 1964.

Complex Instruction Set Computer (CISC)

This has many very specific, specialized instructions, some may never be used in most programs. In CISC, one instruction can denote an execution of several low-level operations or one instruction is capable of multi-step operations and/or addressing modes.

The term was coined after RISC, so everything that is not RISC tends to get lumped here. It's become somewhat of a contentious point since some modern CISC designs are in fact less complex than some RISC designs. The main difference is that CISC architectures have arithmetic/computation instructions also perform memory accesses.

Most architectures were classified after the fact since the term wasn't around at the time of their birth. Some examples include IBM's System/360 and System Z, the PDP-11, the VAX architecture, and Data General's Nova.

Very Long Instruction Word (VLIW) and Explicitly Parallel Instruction Computing (EPIC)

These were designed to exploit instruction level parallelism, executing multiple instructions in parallel. This requires less hardware than CISC or RISC and leaves the complexity for the compiler.

Traditionally, processors use a few different ways to improve performance, let's dig into these.

Pipelining divides instructions into substeps so the instructions can be executed partly at the same time.

Superscalar architectures dispatch individual instructions to be executed independently in different parts of the processor.

Out-of-order execution executes instructions in an order different from the program.

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HERO IMAGE

Cornbread Hemp at a glance:

products work quickly, according to our testers

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Our team visiting the Cornbread Hemp farm in Kentucky

1,2,3 widget/cards (on its own)

1,2,3 widget/cards (3 together for shop story section)

FAQs

Do hair loss treatments work?

Some people find success with hair loss treatments, such as over-the-counter (OTC) medications, prescription medications, and home remedies. But these methods don't work for everyone.

Hair transplants are usually more successful than OTC products. But if you have widespread thinning or baldness or if your hair loss is due to chemotherapy or medications, transplants will not be as effective.

How long does it take hair loss treatments to work?

It's crucial to understand that hair loss treatments take time and commitment. Many of the brands above offer the same prescriptions, and all recommend using them for at least 3 to 6 months daily.

Six months and beyond, your hair loss should have stopped or slowed, and you may see signs of regrowth. But don't stop there — you'll have to continue using these products indefinitely to continue seeing results. It can get expensive over time.

What happens if I stop hair loss treatment?

It depends on the treatment you're using. If you're taking an OTC or prescription medication, you'll have to keep taking it long term to maintain results.

Cam's Success With Noom Med

Cam K, 29. lost 35 lbs in 35 weeks.

"My experience working with Noom has been nothing short of fantastic. Since starting Noom, I've noticed a significant reduction in food noise and cravings and, thanks to the lessons and coaching support, I feel confident that I have built up health habits that will help me maintain my weight loss for years to come." +

Weight Loss Designed For You, Trusted By Us

Noom Med is an accessible and affordable weight loss program that pairs psychology with medication, ensuring healthy transformation and lasting results .

With Noom Med and GLP-1 medication, users experience 48% more weight loss in 6 months than those using medications alone.*

Noom understands that weight loss is most effective when tailored to your individual needs. Complete a quick online quiz, and Noom will recommend a custom plan to achieve your health goals.

97% of doctors recommend combining GLP-1s with lifestyle changes. ^ That's why the Noom app provides a GLP-1 companion to support reliable and long-lasting healthy habits .

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'How Apple Became Apple: The Definitive Oral History of the Company's Earliest Days'

John Gruber · Daring Fireball

This feature from Harry McCracken is just spectacularly good. (And it's a gift link that'll get you past Fast Company's pay-wall.) 50 years is a long time and there are some key players in Apple's origin story who are gone — but because everyone was so young at the time, it's amazing how many of them are still alive. And, of course, in Chris Espinosa's case, still working at Apple:

I was sitting there in the Byte Shop in Palo Alto on an Apple-1 writing BASIC programs, and this guy with a scraggly beard and no shoes came in and looked at me and conducted what I later understood to be the standard interview, which was "Who are you?" I said, "I'm Chris." And he said, "What are you doing?" I said, "I'm writing BASIC programs on this Apple-1 for the owner." And he said, "Are

you any good?" I showed him my BASIC programs on the Apple-1.

He told me, "I've seen you around Homebrew. Woz is working on this second-generation computer, and instead of loading BASIC from cassette tape, we want to put it in ROM. And so it has to be perfect. I want you to come and test Woz's BASIC, and I'll give you 4K of RAM for that when you build your own computer." That sounded like a good deal. Steve Jobs's idea back then of recruiting was to grab a random-ass 14-year-old off the streets.

Apple is at its best when it's infused with a bit of the spirit of the two Steves whose first joint venture were blue boxes that let you make long distance phone calls for free. The first public phone call Steve Jobs ever made on an iPhone was a prank call to the Starbucks next to Moscone West. I feel like that rene-

Weekly Update 485

Troy Hunt

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15 mins and 40 seconds. That's how long it took to troubleshoot the first tech problem of 2026, and that's how far you'll need to skip through this video to hear the audio at normal volume. The problem Scott and I had is analogous to the troubleshooting so many of us do in our roles day in and day out:

This should work fine

It doesn't work, and I don't know why

I did something that seems unrelated, and now it works

I still don't know why

Anyway, I've cleaned up the audio-only version for the podcast, but I can't change the YouTube version once it's streamed, so apologies, just pump your volume up for the first quarter hour. And Happy New Year!

IN BRIEF

Bonface Landi, Inhabitat: As the world becomes increasingly conscious of energy consumption and sustainability, the push toward renewable energy alternatives continues to gain momentum. Among these alternatives, solar power has become one of the most accessible and popular options, especially in portable energy solutions. From emergency preparedness to off-grid adventures, portable solar kits redefine how people access electricity when traditional power sources are unavailable or unreliable.

This April, OptiSolex, has...

New Scientist Space, New Scientist Space: The levels of a heavy form of hydrogen in 3I/ATLAS are 30 to 40 times higher than in Earth's oceans, suggesting the comet has a cold and distant origin

Ben Turner, Live Science: NASA announces moon base, Iran war releases staggering carbon emissions, why weed gives people munchies, and Artemis II preps for liftoff.

New Scientist Space, New Scientist Space: One of the astronauts aboard the International Space Station is undergoing a "medical situation", forcing NASA to bring the crew home early for the first time ever

John Gruber, Daring Fireball: For your weekend listening enjoyment: Christina Warren returns to the show to discuss Apple big month of product announcements — in particular, the iPhone 17e and MacBook Neo. And we pour one out for the Mac Pro.

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Bonface Landi, Inhabitat: Where Form Meets Real-World Function

Some materials earn their place in a space because they're tough. Others, because they look stunning. And then there are those rare few that manage to tick both boxes—materials that not only catch the eye but genuinely improve the way a space performs. Reflective surfaces fall into that category.

From commercial buildings to kitchens and retail interiors, reflective materials offer far more than just shine. Their visual appeal is obvious, sure. But what's...

John Gruber, Daring Fireball: Here's a post from 2013, linking to Rene Ritchie, in which he explains how a great many axes used to chop wood for fires and build

The Urban Digest

Vol. 1, No. 089 · 2026-03-30

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